

What is an Opinion Essay? / 意見エッセイとは何か？

An opinion essay is a formal piece of writing where you share your viewpoint on a specific topic. Your goal is to convince the reader that your opinion is correct by using clear reasons and examples.

意見エッセイとは、特定のトピックについて自分の見解を述べるフォーマルな文章です。明確な理由と例を使って、自分の意見が正しいことを読者に納得させることが目的です。

Key features / 主な特徴

- a) It presents a clear opinion or position. / 明確な意見または立場を示す。
- b) It uses reasons and examples to support the opinion. / 意見を裏付ける理由と例を使用する。
- c) It follows a clear structure. / 明確な構造に従う。
- d) It uses formal language. / フォーマルな言葉遣いを使用する。

A. Structure / 構造

An opinion essay has five main parts. Each part has a specific purpose. / 意見エッセイには5つの主要な部分があります。それぞれの部分には特定の目的があります。

Part	Purpose
Introduction	Introduce the topic and state your opinion clearly. トピックを紹介し、自分の意見を明確に述べる。
Body Paragraph 1	Give your first reason with examples and explanations. 1つ目の理由を、例と説明を使って述べる。
Body Paragraph 2	Give your second reason with examples and explanations. 2つ目の理由を、例と説明を使って述べる。
Body Paragraph 3	Present the opposite opinion and explain why you disagree. 反対意見を示し、なぜ同意しないかを説明する。
Conclusion	Restate your opinion and summarize your main point. 自分の意見を言い直し、主なポイントをまとめる。

Part 1: The Introduction / 序論

The introduction has two important jobs. / 序論には 2 つの重要な役割があります。

- ① Introduce the topic in an interesting way / 興味深い方法でトピックを紹介する
- ② State your opinion clearly (this is your thesis statement) / 意見を明確に述べる（これが論文ステートメント）

Example

Topic: Should government employees be allowed to work remotely on a permanent basis?

The COVID-19 pandemic made many government workers start working from home. Now, some people think employees should go back to the office. Other people think they should continue working from home. **In my opinion, government employees should be allowed to work remotely on a permanent basis** because remote work helps people work better and makes employees happier.

Note / 注意

The first two sentences introduce the topic. The third sentence is the thesis statement that clearly states the writer's opinion.

最初の 2 文でトピックを紹介しています。3 文目が論文ステートメントで、筆者の意見を明確に述べています。

Useful Phrases

Introductions

- Many people believe that...
- Nowadays, there is a lot of discussion about...
- It is often said that...
- One of the most important questions today is...

Stating your opinion

- In my opinion...
- I strongly believe that...
- From my point of view...
- I am convinced that...

Part 2: Body Paragraphs 1 & 2 (Supporting Your Opinion) / 本論（意見の裏付け）

Each body paragraph should have: / 各本論パラグラフには以下が必要です：

- ① A topic sentence that introduces your main reason / 主要な理由を紹介するトピック文
- ② Supporting details and examples / 裏付けとなる詳細と例
- ③ An explanation of how your example supports your opinion / 例がどのように意見を裏付けるかの説明

Body Paragraph 1

First of all, remote work can help people work better. When employees work from home, they do not need to travel to the office. This saves time. They also have fewer interruptions from other workers and can focus on their work. **For example**, a study by our ministry found that employees who worked from home finished their projects 15% faster than those who worked in the office. They said the quiet environment at home helped them concentrate better. **As a result**, remote work can help employees do better work and save government money.

Body Paragraph 2

Secondly, working from home makes employees happier. Employees can manage their personal lives better when they work remotely. They can take care of their families and still do their work. **For instance**, many employees in our department said that working from home lets them pick up their children from school and finish their work in the evening. This flexibility makes them less stressed and feel more valued. **This means that** employees want to stay in their jobs longer. **Therefore**, remote work helps government ministries keep good workers and saves money on training new staff.

Useful Phrases

Topic sentences

- First of all... / Firstly...
- Secondly... / Another reason is...
- The main reason why...

Explaining

- This means that...
- As a result...
- Therefore

Giving examples

- For example...
- For instance...
- To illustrate this point...

Part 3: Body Paragraphs 3 The Counter-Argument / 反論パラグラフ

In this paragraph, you show that you understand the opposite opinion, but you explain why you still disagree. This makes your essay stronger because it shows you have considered different viewpoints.

このパラグラフでは、反対意見を理解していることを示しながら、なぜそれでも同意しないかを説明します。これにより、異なる視点を考慮したことが示され、エッセイがより強力になります。

Body Paragraph 3

Some people believe that government employees should work in the office because working together face-to-face is important. They say that remote work makes communication harder and can cause problems. **However, I disagree with this view because** modern technology gives us good tools for communication. Video calls, messaging apps, and project software help teams work together well from different places. In fact, many teams found that online meetings can be better than office meetings because they are more organized and focused. **Therefore,** we can solve communication problems by using technology correctly.

Useful Phrases

Introducing the opposite opinion

- Some people believe that...
- It is sometimes argued that...
- Opponents of this view claim that...

Disagreeing

- However, I disagree with this view because...
- Nevertheless, I believe that...
- While this may be true, I think that...

Part 4: The Conclusion / 結論

The conclusion has two main purposes. / 結論には 2 つの主な目的があります。

- ① Restate your opinion using different words / 異なる言葉で意見を言い換える
- ② Summarize your main reasons / 主要な理由を要約する

Example

In conclusion, I strongly believe that remote work is good for both government employees and the government. Remote work helps people be more productive because they can work in quiet places and do not waste time traveling. Also, it makes employees happier because they can balance their work and personal life better. **Although** some people worry that remote work makes teamwork difficult, modern technology helps teams communicate well from anywhere. **Therefore**, government ministries should let their employees work from home permanently.

Note / 注意

Do not introduce new ideas in the conclusion. Also, do not simply copy sentences from your introduction. / 結論で新しいアイデアを導入しないでください。また、序論の文をそのままコピーしないでください。

Useful Phrases

Conclusions

- In conclusion...
- To sum up...
- All in all...
- Taking everything into account...

B. Analyzing a Weak Essay / 弱いエッセイの分析

Before we look at a good example, let's analyze a weak essay. This will help you understand what to avoid in your own writing.

良い例を見る前に、弱いエッセイを分析してみましょう。これにより、自分の文章で避けるべきことを理解できます。

Example

Topic: *Should companies allow employees to work from home?*

I think working from home is good. Many people like it because it's convenient. You don't have to wake up early and you can stay in your pajamas all day. It's very comfortable. First, working from home save time. You don't need to commute. My friend spend 2 hours everyday going to office and coming back. That's a lot of time! If he work from home, he can use that time for other thing. Second, it's save money too. You don't need to buy lunch or coffee. Also gas for car is expensive. My colleague told me she saves about \$200 per month by working from home. This is very good for people who don't have much money. But some people say working from home is bad. They think people will be lazy and watch TV all day. I think this is not true because most people are responsible. So I disagree. In conclusion, I think working from home is really good. It saves time and money. Everyone should work from home because it's better. Companies should let all employees do it starting from tomorrow.

Analysis / 分析

Read the essay above carefully and answer these questions. Try to find as many problems as possible. / 上記のエッセイを注意深く読み、以下の質問に教えてください。できるだけ多くの問題を見つけてみてください。

1. Structure / 構造に関する

- a) Does the introduction properly introduce the topic? What is missing?
序論は適切にトピックを紹介していますか？何が欠けていますか？
- b) Does the essay have a clear thesis statement? Where should it be?
エッセイには明確な論文ステートメントがありますか？それはどこにあるべきですか？
- c) How many body paragraphs does this essay have? Is this the correct structure?
このエッセイには本論パラグラフがいくつありますか？これは正しい構造ですか？
- d) Does the counter-argument paragraph properly present and refute the opposing view?
反論パラグラフは、反対意見を適切に提示し、反論していますか？
- e) Does the conclusion properly summarize the main points? What problems do you see?
結論は主要なポイントを適切に要約していますか？どんな問題が見えますか？

2. Content and Logic / 内容と論理に関する

- a) Are the reasons in the body paragraphs strong and well-developed?
本論パラグラフの理由は強力で、よく展開されていますか？
- b) Are the examples specific and convincing? What could be improved?
例は具体的で説得力がありますか？何を改善できますか？
- c) Does each body paragraph have proper explanation of how the example supports the opinion?
各本論パラグラフには、例がどのように意見を裏付けるかの適切な説明がありますか？

3. Language and Style / 言語とスタイルに関する

- a) Is the language formal or informal? Find examples of informal language.
言葉遣いはフォーマルですか、それともインフォーマルですか？インフォーマルな言葉の例を見つけてください。
- b) Find at least 5 grammar errors in the essay.
エッセイの中から少なくとも5つの文法エラーを見つけください。
- c) Does the writer use good linking words to connect ideas?
筆者はアイデアをつなぐために適切な接続詞を使っていますか？
- d) Are the sentences varied in length and structure, or are they too simple?
文の長さや構造は変化に富んでいますか、それとも単純すぎますか？

Common Problems / 見られる問題

After you answer the questions above, check your answers against this list. / 上記の質問に答えた後、この一覧と照らし合わせて確認してください。

1. Structure Problems / 構造の問題

- No proper topic introduction starts immediately with opinion
適切なトピック紹介がない すぐに意見から始まっている
- Thesis statement is unclear and too simple
論文ステートメントが不明瞭で単純すぎる
- Body paragraphs are too short and underdeveloped
本論パラグラフが短すぎて展開が不十分
- Counter-argument is poorly developed (only 2 sentences!)
反論が不十分（たった2文！）
- Conclusion introduces new ideas and makes unrealistic claims
結論が新しいアイデアを導入し、非現実的な主張をしている

2. Content Problems / 内容の問題

- Reasons are weak and obvious ("it's convenient", "saves money")
理由が弱く、当たり前（「便利」「お金が節約できる」）
- Examples are too personal and not well-explained
例が個人的すぎて、十分に説明されていない
- No real explanation of how examples support the main argument
例がどのように主張を裏付けるかの本当の説明がない
- Counter-argument doesn't seriously consider opposing views
反論が反対意見を真剣に考慮していない

3. Language Problems / 言語の問題

- Informal language: "I think" (instead of "In my opinion"), "really good", "all day"
インフォーマルな言葉遣い：「I think」（「In my opinion」の代わりに）、「really good」、「all day」
- Grammar errors: "save" (should be "saves"), "spend" (should be "spends"), "work" (should be "works"), "thing" (should be "things"), "it's save" (should be "it saves")
文法エラー：「save」（「saves」であるべき）、「spend」（「spends」であるべき）、など
- Repetitive sentence structure too many simple sentences
文構造の繰り返し 単純な文が多すぎる
- Poor use of linking words mostly missing
接続詞の使用が不十分 ほとんどない

C. A Complete Opinion Essay / 完全な意見エッセイ

Now that you've seen what NOT to do, let's look at a well-written example. / やってはいけないことを見たので、次によく書かれた例を見てみましょう。

Topic: *Should governments invest more money in public transportation infrastructure?*

Many cities have serious problems with traffic and air pollution. As more people move to cities, these problems are getting worse. Some people think that investing in public transportation is the answer. Other people think governments should spend money on different things. In my opinion, governments should invest more money in public transportation because it helps the environment and makes the economy better.

First of all, public transportation reduces pollution. Private cars create a lot of air pollution and greenhouse gases in cities. When more people use buses, trains, and subways instead of cars, pollution goes down. For example, studies show that one bus can replace up to 40 private cars on the road. This means that a good public transportation system can reduce carbon emissions by millions of tons each year. Also, many modern public transportation systems now use electric vehicles, which create even less pollution. Therefore, investing in public transportation is one of the best ways for governments to fight climate change and improve air quality.

Secondly, good public transportation helps the economy. When workers can travel quickly and easily, they get to work on time and feel less stressed. This helps them do better work. Also, when there is less traffic, businesses can move their products through the city faster. For instance, cities like Tokyo and Singapore have excellent public transportation systems. These cities report that their transit systems save businesses billions of dollars every year because of faster travel times and lower transportation costs. Moreover, building and maintaining public transportation creates many jobs. As a result, the economic benefits are much greater than the costs.

Some people argue that building public transportation is too expensive. They say governments should spend money on other things like healthcare or education. While these are important, I believe this argument is wrong. The costs of traffic problems are very high. These include lost time, wasted fuel, and health problems from pollution. Studies show that these costs are often higher than the cost of building public transportation. Furthermore, public transportation and other services are not opposites. In fact, good transportation helps people access healthcare and education more easily. Therefore, investing in public transportation actually helps governments provide other important services.

In conclusion, I strongly support more government investment in public transportation. This investment helps the environment by reducing pollution and improving air quality. It also helps the economy by reducing traffic problems and saving businesses money. Although building public transportation costs a lot of money at first, the long-term benefits are much greater. These benefits include better environmental health, a stronger economy, and improved public health. For these reasons, governments should make public transportation development a top priority.

Important Tips for Success / 成功のための重要なヒント

- ① **Use formal language:** Avoid contractions (write "do not" instead of "don't") and informal expressions (like "kids" or "gonna").
フォーマルな言葉遣いを使用する： 短縮形（"don't"ではなく"do not"）や非公式な表現（"kids"や"gonna"など）を避けてください。
- ② **Use linking words:** Words like "however," "furthermore," "moreover," and "therefore" help connect your ideas smoothly.
接続詞を使用する： "however"、"furthermore"、"moreover"、"therefore"などの言葉は、アイデアをスムーズにつなげるのに役立ちます。
- ③ **Provide specific examples:** General statements are not as convincing as specific examples from your experience or knowledge.
具体的な例を示す： 一般的な陳述は、経験や知識からの具体的な例ほど説得力がありません。
- ④ **Check your grammar:** Pay special attention to verb tenses, subject-verb agreement, and article usage.
文法を確認する： 動詞の時制、主語と動詞の一致、冠詞の使用に特に注意してください。
- ⑤ **Plan before you write:** Spend a few minutes making an outline with your main points before you start writing.
書く前に計画する： 書き始める前に、主要なポイントを含むアウトラインを作成するのに数分かけてください。
- ⑥ **Proofread your essay:** Always read your essay at least once after finishing to catch any mistakes.
エッセイを校正する： 終了後、必ず少なくとも一度エッセイを読み返して、間違いを見つけてください。

Final Words / 最後の言葉

Writing a good opinion essay takes practice. Do not be discouraged if your first essays are not perfect. The more you practice, the better you will become. Remember to follow the structure, use clear examples, and express your ideas confidently. Good luck with your writing!

良い意見エッセイを書くには練習が必要です。最初のエッセイが完璧でなくても落胆しないでください。練習すればするほど、上達します。構造に従い、明確な例を使用し、自信を持ってアイデアを表現することを忘れないでください。頑張ってください！